He turned and walked to his desk, then sat down. “You don’t want anyone to die, do you, Rose?” he said, kindly.

“No.”

He smiled, and a small flicker of hope bloomed inside her.

“You see, I understand you better than you understand yourself.” He pushed a small box toward her. “I have a proposition for you.”

She swallowed, her eyes on the box.

“Open it,” he said.

“A proposition?”

“You no longer have to decide who will live and die. Open the box; then you’ll understand.” His tone was firmer now.

She took the box and opened it. Inside was a ring—two small diamonds set in a simple gold band. “Whose ring is it?”

“It’s yours. You take it and all the women will live. You don’t take it—all nineteen women will be dead at dawn.”

Throat tight, her heart pitched like a barge in roiling waves. “I don’t understand. What happens if I take it?”

“Then you will be my wife.”

“Marry you?”

“Marry me.”

A rushing in her head followed by a surge of darkness. Overwhelmed by shock, she closed her eyes and sank back against the chair. She could feel herself plummeting down into deep, cold water. She was back in Orléans, diving into the Loire like when she’d been a child, and she wouldn’t come up for air. Holding her breath, she would try to stay under for as long as she could, watching the bubbles escape her mouth and nose. There was nothing on the surface of the water for her to return to—go deep and hide where it’s safe. And then, she felt a buoy slip under her arms, and a force dragging her to the surface. The stench of wet wool mixed with sweat on his uniform. She opened her eyes: he was again standing in front of her.

“I will not repeat my offer.”

“Marry you . . . properly?”

“I want you to remain here with me after the war.”

“But I must return to France, that is my home.”

“That will be your choice.”

But what choice did she have? No matter what she said to him, her life